larly bothersome strictures relating to small offences. Removing official boundary markers during construction on an allotted industrial plot constituted a crime under the IPC and could land you in the cooler for a year. Unauthorised procurement of water for industrial use would attract 2-3 months of jail.

The fear of jail, even for inadvertent errors, stifled innovation, particularly among MSMEs and startups, he says, adding: "Allowing officers to settle disputes and offences has created a balance of do's and don'ts."

Industries minister Balvantsinh Rajput says the Bill was drafted after studying the Union Jan Vishwas Act 2023, which tamed 183 provisions in 42 central laws, and its August 2025 upgrade that further decriminalised

Takeaways

- **Gujarat's version of the Jan Vishwas Bill drops the prison clause from 516 offences**
- **State had India's highest prison clauses: 1,469**
- **Most replaced by fines. MSMEs to benefit most**

355 provisions across 16 Acts. Rajput says moving to "trust-based governance" would alleviate the judiciary's crippling load: trivial cases make up much of its 50 million pending cases.

Opposition MLAs say the Bill prioritises ease for offenders over justice for citizens, pointing out that it gives immense powers to officials: they will now be the law, with no judicial oversight. AAP MLA Gopal Italia also cited conflicting provisions where the Bill calls for a fine but the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita stipulates a jail term "for the same crime". But overall, the BJP government has burnished its pro-business credentials. Even skeptics concede that the real win is psychological as businesses now breathe freer. ■



CELEB HUNTING Dulquer Salmaan and Prithviraj Sukumaran

KERALA

Wheels

Sensation is matched by links Mollywood stars to a

By **Jeemon Jacob**

BHUTANESE IS NOT A LANGUAGE you might expect to hear in Kerala. But then, words have wheels. High-end wheels, to take the word of the good people in law enforcement. It was late September when the phrase 'Operation Numkhor' leapt across Kerala's windshield—numkhor means 'vehicle' in Bhutanese. It was the exotic name given by the Customs Preventive Wing for its swoop-down against a cross-border luxury car racket, said to run from the Himalayan kingdom all the way down the tarmac to the deep south. As the sleuths dredged through the swishier parts of Kerala high society, the number of top-end models seized touched 43.

That story had enough fuel to travel continents. But what really set it vrooming was the roster of names it fetched up. A directory of Mollywood A-listers: stars like Dulquer Salmaan and Prithviraj Sukumaran, others like Amith Chakkalakkal. Then, as Kerala swung between shock and schadenfreude, the script turned. A new actor landed on the scene: the Enforcement Directorate.

SHOCK AND AWE

On October 8, the ED conducted raids in 17 locations, ostensibly to probe unauthorised transactions in the racket. Dulquer, Prithviraj and Chakkalakkal figured, of course. So did the NRI owners of Coimbatore-based Shine Motors. The ED's raid parties even reached the residences of superstar Mammootty, Dulquer's father. Dulquer himself was summoned from Chennai to Kochi and interrogated for five hours.

The usual formal statements were outed. Officials spoke of having seized documents related to the purchase of high-end used cars and suspected prima facie violations of foreign exchange rules, hawala transactions, the works. It was the culmination, they said, of months of digging by the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs after a tip-off from the Vehicle Registration Department. The Coimbatore-based network linked to the NRIs was monitored. The stated modus operandi: it would use forged papers with grand-sounding associations—including the Indian army, the US embassy and the MEA—to register cars in Arunachal Pradesh and Himachal Pradesh. This luxury cavalcade would then purr its way to a circuit of celebrities, business magnates and NRIs with a fondness for luxury cars.